

‘A Psychological Riddle Demanding a Solution’. Crowd Psychology and the Finnish Civil War of 1918

Abstract:

Right after the Finnish Civil War of 1918, the first treatises discussing the insurgents (the Reds) in crowd psychological terms were published. Between 1918 and the early 1920s, several Finnish authors used Gustave Le Bon's and other crowd psychologists' ideas of suggestion, mental epidemics, and the dangers of socialism in their interpretations of the aborted revolution. The article argues that the use of crowd psychology in the years following the Finnish Civil War was an attempt to articulate in objective, scientific language an emotional and moral reaction to the shock of seeing a nation violently divided and tearing itself apart. Intrinsic to Finnish interpretations of crowd psychology were the increasing antagonism between socialists and anti-socialists, the influence of Bolshevism on the worker's movement, the importance attributed to the 'racial' qualities of the people, and the impact of the Civil War on the educated classes – all issues that are easy to relate to wider European and global contexts. This article lends support to the thesis that crowd psychology was an influential intellectual construction that had great heuristic value among contemporaries from the late nineteenth century to World War II.

Keywords: Crowd psychology; Finnish Civil War; Gustave Le Bon; Socialism; Bolshevism; race

1. Introduction

In late 1917, following the October Revolution in Russia, Finland gained independence from the Tsarist Empire, but only a few months later, the young nation experienced a short but brutal civil war.¹ It was a class war insofar as revolutionary ‘Red Guards’ fought against anti-socialist ‘White’ troops – and ultimately lost. The Civil War was an explosion that both revealed and fanned the atmosphere of hate and animosity in the newly independent nation. At the same time, far from being an isolated local conflict in the European periphery, the Finnish Civil War needs to be seen in the context of World War I, as one of the upheavals it brought about in the European fringe areas, including parts of the Habsburg Empire, the Baltic region and the Russian Empire.²

¹ For book-length studies in English or German on the Civil War, see Tuomas Tepora and Aapo Roselius, eds, *The Finnish Civil War 1918: History, Memory, Legacy* (Leiden, 2018); Anthony F. Upton, *The Finnish Revolution 1917-1918* (Minneapolis, 1980); Risto Alapuro, *State and Revolution in Finland* (Berkeley, CA, 1988); Tuomas Hoppu and Pertti Haapala, eds, *Tampere 1918: A Town in the Civil War* (Tampere, 2010); Heikki Ylikangas, *Der Weg nach Tampere: Die Niederlage der Roten im finnischen Bürgerkrieg 1918* (Berlin, 2002). See also Juha Siltala, ‘Dissolution and Reintegration in Finland, 1914–1932: How Did a Disarmed Country Become Absorbed into Brutalization?’, *Journal of Baltic Studies* 46 (2015): 11-33.

² For the history of civil wars in Europe during the first half of the twentieth century, see Stanley G. Payne, *Civil War in Europe, 1905-1949* (Cambridge, 2011). On paramilitary violence affecting Eastern and Central Europe between 1917 and the early 1920s, see Robert Gerwarth and John Horne, ‘Vectors of Violence: Paramilitarism in Europe after the Great War, 1917-1923’, *The Journal of Modern History* 83 (2011): 489-512.

By the spring of 1918, the first treatises about the Civil War were being published in Finland. In these accounts, the middle-class authors often used notions of crowd psychology borrowed from, among others, Gustave Le Bon, Vladimir Bekhterev, Gabriel Tarde, and Willy Hellpach that were very popular in Europe and North America at this time. While the ideas of Le Bon and some other crowd psychologists have been examined in some detail,³ there are very few studies which focus on how crowd psychology has been used in specific historical instances. In the United States, Joseph W. Bendersky has studied how Le Bon's psychology was applied by the U.S. military between the two world wars while Eugene E. Leach has written about how crowd psychology was discussed and applied by American social scientists and psychologists from the late nineteenth to early twentieth century, and how it was a precursor of mass society theories.⁴

This article focuses on the application of crowd psychology in a particular historical setting, that of a small Northern European country in the aftermath of a civil war. Using numerous

³ Robert A. Nye, *The Origins of Crowd Psychology: Gustave Le Bon and the Crisis of Mass Democracy in the Third Republic* (London, 1975); Serge Moscovici, *The Age of the Crowd: A Historical Treatise on Mass Psychology* (Cambridge, 1985); J.S. McClelland, *The Crowd and the Mob* (London, 1989); Jaap van Ginneken, *Crowds, Psychology and Politics 1871–1899* (New York, 1992); Christian Borch, *The Politics of Crowds: An Alternative History of Sociology* (Cambridge, 2012).

⁴ Joseph W. Bendersky, "'Panic': The Impact of Le Bon's Crowd Psychology on U.S. Military Thought', *Journal of the History of the Behavioral Sciences* 43 (2007): 257-283; Eugene E. Leach, "'Mental epidemics'. Crowd psychology and American culture, 1890-1940', *American Studies* 33 (1992): 5-29; Eugene E. Leach, 'Mastering the Crowd: Collective Behavior and the Mass Society in American Social Thought, 1917-1939', *American Studies* 27 (1986): 99-114.

publications – newspapers, books, booklets, and articles – written by contemporaries as sources, I will argue that the use of crowd psychology immediately after the Finnish Civil War was an attempt to articulate in an objective, scientific language an emotional and moral reaction to the shock of seeing a nation violently divided and tearing itself apart.⁵

In this article, I will be looking closely at possible determinants affecting both the popularity of crowd psychology and its various interpretations immediately following the Civil War. As this article focuses on the manifestations of crowd psychology in a civil war context, I will not discuss the references to crowd psychology made by psychiatrists and other mental health professionals, because their interpretations were usually made within the framework of psychiatry and forensic mental health – not an explicitly political or cultural setting. I will start with a short description of Le Bon's crowd psychology, and then outline the developments preceding the insurgence to better clarify the reasons why crowd psychology became popular as an explanatory framework in Finland. In the next three sections, based on a close reading of sources, I will then illustrate and analyse interpretations of crowd psychology, as expressed by Finnish-speaking and Swedish-speaking authors, respectively. I follow these linguistic lines, because their interpretations of the Civil War, while sharing many assumptions, had some clear

⁵ I have systematically gone through the main cultural magazines published in Finland between 1918 and 1939 (including *Nya Argus*, *Finsk Tidskrift*, *Valvoja* and *Aika*). I then used the Finnish crowd psychology keywords I found of 'Le Bon', 'mass psychosis', 'group madness', 'suggestion', 'hypnosis' and 'psychic infection' to search for references in the digitised collection of newspapers and magazines at the National Library. I also searched for such references to crowd psychology in the monographs published by Finnish intellectuals and leading socialists in the five-year period after the Civil War. I also used the *Finna* library database to look for memoirs and other potentially relevant books published after 1925.

differences. The thematic issues to be explored in these key-sections include the ways crowd psychology allowed the Reds to be pathologised in psycho-medical terms, and how it coloured views on parliamentary democracy, suffrage, race, language, and ethnicity. I will then discuss why crowd psychology became so popular in Finland after the Civil War. Finally, I make some general observations about crowd psychology and its historical study.

2. Le Bon's crowd psychology as social psychology of the industrialised age

French author Gustave Le Bon's *The Crowd: A Study of the Popular Mind* (*Psychologie des Foules*, 1895) was published in Finland under the title 'Group Mind' (*Joukkosielu*) in 1912 – when the country was still an autonomous Grand Duchy within the Russian Empire. The book came out that same year in Sweden, too. Le Bon was by no means the only crowd psychologist read by Finnish authors, but he was by far the most cited and discussed. This was anything but unusual, since Le Bon's book was enjoying great popularity internationally: it was constantly referred to in both academic and non-academic publications for more than half a century, was translated into at least 16 languages,⁶ and remains in print. At the time it was published, social psychology was a nascent field that was, to a great extent, synonymous with crowd psychology. Other crowd psychologists included French sociologist Gabriel Tarde, Italian criminologist Scipio Sighele, British-American psychologist William McDougall, and Ukrainian-born American psychologist and psychiatrist Boris Sidis. Le Bon actually took many of his ideas from Tarde and Sighele and made them more palatable to the general public. Le Bon's popularity lasted until the 1950s, when a new generation of social psychologists started to

⁶ Nye, *The Origins of Crowd Psychology*, 3.

develop new theories on the behaviour of crowds, or ‘collective behaviour’, as the issue became typically framed.⁷

Keenly interested in the research on hypnosis, somnambulism, and hysteria, Le Bon applied concepts from the French ‘Psychopathological School’ to society and social behaviour, containing sweeping assertions about the ‘extreme mental inferiority of crowds’,⁸ and the hypnotic model of leadership, in which crowds are prone to internalise the commands and promises of an individual willing and able to manipulate their unconscious impulses and channel their energies for political ends. In Le Bon’s book, the crowd was portrayed as an irrational and potentially destructive entity.

Le Bon’s main contention was that, rather than relying individually on laws and institutions, crowds are powerless to ‘hold any opinions other than those which are imposed upon them’ by suggestion.⁹ In ‘every human agglomeration’, Le Bon maintained, these suggestions ‘are contagious’, and trigger ‘the mechanism of the collective hallucinations so frequent in history’.¹⁰ In modern times, and here we come closer to the issues discussed in this article, he argued, terms such as ‘democracy, socialism, equality, liberty, etc.’ have been particularly

⁷ The concept of ‘collective behaviour’ was developed already in the 1920s by the Chicago School of Sociology, to which social psychology was one of the building blocks (the pioneers of the Chicago School also sometimes used the term ‘collective psychology’ instead of ‘social psychology’). See Robert E. Park and Ernest Burgess, *The City* (Chicago, 2019, 1st edition 1925), 22. For more on links between the Chicago School and European crowd psychology, see Borch, *The Politics of Crowds*, 140-150.

⁸ Gustave Le Bon, *The Crowd. A Study of the Popular Mind* (New York, 1960), 4.

⁹ Le Bon, *The Crowd*, 20.

¹⁰ Le Bon, *The Crowd*, 42-43.

suggestive because, though ill-defined, they evoke powerful images. Such magic words ‘synthesise the most diverse unconscious aspirations and the hope of their realization’, as if they ‘contained the solution of all problems’.¹¹ Two major examples of the influence of suggestive words on the crowds, he contended, were the French Revolution and, perhaps more pressingly, the ‘threatening invasion of socialism’. The former began by establishing the masses as a political force, while the latter was a consequence ‘of strong impressions produced on the imagination of the crowd’.¹² In contrast to religions proper, socialism promised salvation for the time being, but would lose its prestige as soon as it triumphed and its ideas put into practice. Until that day, socialism would gain in strength, because its empty promises would have a suggestive force upon the masses. Le Bon had, after all, witnessed first-hand the Paris Commune of 1871 which, at the time he was writing (1895), had been the most recent example of how a crowd could turn into a destructive mob.¹³

For many contemporaries, Le Bon and other crowd psychologists were seen as forecasters of a crisis, and the core political message of *The Crowd* certainly is alarmist; Le Bon warns that the ‘opinion of crowds tends [...] more and more to become the supreme guiding principle in politics’.¹⁴ The implication was that all reasonable individuals should beware of revolutions, rebellions, and other disruptive manifestations of crowd psychology – a message he also kept on trumpeting in his 1898 book, the *Psychology of Socialism*. As a constant threat to social order, the group mind – ever ready for crime or to riot – needs to be controlled and tamed.

¹¹ Le Bon, *The Crowd*, 102-103.

¹² Le Bon, *The Crowd*, 69.

¹³ Le Bon discussed the Paris Commune at length in his earlier books, including *L’Homme et les sociétés* (1881).

¹⁴ Le Bon, *The Crowd*, 150.

David McClelland, historian of political thought, has noted that the ‘secret of Le Bon’s success was to use science to frighten the public, and then to claim that what science could understand it could also control’.¹⁵ This is a poignant observation, especially when we add that not everyone was necessarily ‘frightened’ by Le Bon’s warnings. His book influenced individuals such as Robert E. Park (founder of the Chicago School of Sociology), Theodore Roosevelt, Sigmund Freud, Benito Mussolini, Ion Antonescu (the future dictator of Romania), and Adolf Hitler¹⁶. Regarding the last three, it seems as if they might well have read *The Crowd* as a textbook on how to manipulate and control the ‘masses’. Interestingly, and clearly because the Army is an institution predicated on the modification of group behaviour, Le Bon’s ideas also influenced military officers in France, Romania, and the US.¹⁷

The Great War and its aftermath, including socialist uprisings in Germany and Hungary, and the consolidation of Bolshevik rule in Russia, increased the international prestige of crowd psychology in general and Le Bon’s psychology in particular. By the end of the war, Le Bon was, by far, the most well-known and widely read social psychologist in the world.¹⁸ Part of his readership were the Finnish anti-socialists who had defeated the insurgents in the Civil War.

¹⁵ McClelland, *The Crowd and the Mob*, 196.

¹⁶ For more on crowd psychology’s influence on Hitler, see McClelland, *The Crowd and the Mob*, 270-292.

¹⁷ Nye, *The Origins of Crowd Psychology*, 123-153, 165-166; Bendersky, ““Panic””.

¹⁸ Nye, *The Origins of Crowd Psychology*, 167.

3. From the ideal of national unity to the killing fields of the Civil War

To understand how crowd psychology was used to interpret the Finnish Civil War, some essential contextual knowledge about the road to conflict is needed. Finland had been part of Sweden for more than 600 years before it became part of the Russian Empire as a Grand Duchy in 1809. With the emergence of cultural nationalism in the 1830s and 1840s, a core group of influential intellectuals began to emphasise the cultural unity of Finns. As historical sociologist Risto Alapuro points out, what happened in Finland was typical of Eastern European ‘latecomer’ states – ‘[e]thnic similarities led to the emergence of a national consciousness before the formation of the state’.¹⁹ Those who were developing such a consciousness were, for the most part, members of the Swedish-speaking elite, but rather than keep a physical and symbolic distance from common Finnish speakers, they extolled their virtues. If Finns seemed mentally rigid, taciturn, and suspicious of novelty and strangers, these pious yet modest Christians were nevertheless hard-working, humble, and law-abiding.²⁰ As common people spoke Finnish and its numerous dialects, the intellectuals argued that the Swedish-speaking minority should also learn Finnish to create a genuinely unified sense of nationhood – and this is what generally happened. Finnish became an official language in administration and education, and this ‘romance’ with authentic Finnishness culminated in a rather unique process around the turn of the twentieth century, when thousands of Swedish-speaking families

¹⁹ Alapuro, *State and Revolution*, 9.

²⁰ One ‘nation-builder’, historian, journalist, and novelist – Zachris Topelius – used these and similar terms in his description of the typical Finn in 1893. Zachris Topelius, ‘Kansa’, in *Suomi 19:llä vuosisadalla*, ed. L. Mechelin, (Liminka, 2014), 63.

Finnicized their surnames. What also united the elites and ordinary people was common opposition to the Tsar's 'Russification' policies that began in the 1890s.²¹

As historian Jaakko Paavolainen has noted, the general attitude of the Finnish middle classes (*porvaristo*) towards the nascent workers' movement was positive, because it was seen as a force for educating and civilising those less well off. Thus, rather than being in opposition to the more conservative political parties, the workers' movement was widely accepted to be a legitimate mass movement fighting for similar ends as other political groups. The first generation of socialists also considered their movement to be a pacifist one that furthered traditional ideas of Christian brotherhood.²²

However, by the early twentieth century, this classless ideal of harmony between capital and labour was beginning to fracture. The tumult of General Strike in 1905, which began in Russia, was a kind of watershed marking the beginnings of this rupture; as this was followed by the radical political reforms of 1906, which replaced the estates system of representation with parliamentary democracy. In principle, this now gave all men and women over the age of 24 the right to vote in parliamentary elections and resulted in the Social Democratic Party (or Finnish Labour, established in 1899) becoming the biggest party in the country. In fact, in terms of proportion relative to the population of Finland, the SDP was the biggest socialist party of

²¹ Tuomo Polvinen, *Imperial Borderland: Bobrikov and the Attempted Russification of Finland, 1898-1904* (London, 1995).

²² Jaakko Paavolainen, *Suomen kansallinen murhenäytelmä: punainen ja valkoinen terrori ja vankileirit v. 1918* (Helsinki, 1974), 11-13. Paavolainen's 3-volume work, published in the late 1960s and the early 1970s, on the red and white terror as well as the post-war prison camps was a groundbreaking study of the Finnish Civil War.

any country in the world, and also the most rural based.²³ This meant that, though the Tsar had the right to overrule decisions made in Finland's Parliament, the working classes –including tenant farmers and rural workers – now had their own representatives.

Among the more conservative members of the middle classes, the rapid growth of the SDP and the labour movement was of great concern: the humble, obedient peasant had now turned into a self-assertive wage worker who was making strict demands and refusing to comply with some of the rules laid out by owners, employers, and other authorities. To some of the more hostile political observers, the proletariat had become 'suffused with social-democratic class hatred'.²⁴ At the same time, there were tensions between *Fennomans* – advocating the primacy of Finnish language and national culture – and *Svekomans*, who wanted to defend the Swedish language and the country's cultural ties with Sweden. Interestingly however, both these movements started within the Swedish-speaking upper class,²⁵ somewhat blunting the Svekoman cause by the fact that there were several Swedish speakers who also supported certain goals of the Fennomans – e.g., more political autonomy for Finland. However, by the 1910s, the worsening political climate was exacerbating these differences between the Finnish- and Swedish-minded, which grew in tandem with the newly emerging rift between the elite and a growing number of organised workers.

²³ Alapuro, *State and Revolution*, 11.

²⁴ Axel Lille, *Framtidsuppgifter* (Helsingfors, 1918), 23. Lille was founder of the fiercely anti-socialist Swedish People's Party of Finland.

²⁵ Alapuro, *State and Revolution*, 86. For more on Fennomania, see Ilkka Liikanen, *Fennomania ja kansa* (Helsinki, 1995), English summary: "Fennomania and the People: The Breakthrough of Mass Organization and the Birth of the Finnish Party," 349-360.

While not being directly involved in the Great War, Finland was nevertheless affected by its export-driven industry being dramatically weakened. Prices rose, there was a food supply crisis, and by 1917, an increasing number of Finns faced unemployment and poverty. In this period of acute deprivation and a growing black-market economy, the radical and increasingly antagonistic political rhetoric of the more militant socialist faction of the SDP began to have a wider appeal to the working classes. This radicalisation was directly related to the revolution occurring in Russia at the time, which had dramatic effects on both the political system and general atmosphere in Finland. A power vacuum followed the February Revolution in Russia, as the Empire's two main instruments of coercion – the police and army – became largely defunct, leaving the Russian military stations in Finland paralysed. As the state no longer held the monopoly on violence, each opposing camp started to organise their own militia. In the Spring of 1917, the workers' movement was filled with the hope of change and renewal; as one working-class woman described in her memoirs, emotions would run high in the Helsinki workers' meetings she attended, as thousands of people sang the *Internationale* anthem and the words, 'down with the old world'.²⁶

In the late autumn of 1917, partly inspired by the October Revolution in Russia, a more radical faction of the SDP began to consider an armed uprising of their own. And this is what they eventually initiated, though some time after the Bolshevik revolution, in January 1918. Immediately preceding this, on 6 December, the Finnish Parliament had meanwhile declared independence. By this time both the Red Guards and the White Guards opposed to socialism (officially called Protection Guards) began to arm themselves.²⁷ When the war broke out, the

²⁶ Martta Salmela-Järvinen, *Alas lyötiin vanha maailma* (Helsinki 1966), 110.

²⁷ Broadly speaking, the main difference between the Reds and the Whites was that the former were workers and other non-owners, and the latter were (more or less) middle-class owners of property

Red Guards quickly took control of the south and the most industrial parts of Finland. Helsinki, the capital, was firmly in the hands of the revolutionaries, and so were the other major towns in the south. In the more agrarian parts of the country in the north and east, the White Guards had managed to gain control, after some scuffles with Red Guards, and they had now become the official government troops, once the government had relocated to the coastal town of Vaasa in January. Although the Whites were by and large middle-class, most of the White Guard soldiers came from the freeholding peasantry, while the Red Guards were mostly industrial workers, craftsmen, and landless labourers. In addition, there were also a relatively small number of Russian soldiers who fought with the Reds. From the beginning, the very idea of the revolution had been quite vague, or Kautskyist in its reformism, among the Finnish socialists, and there were actually very few SPD leaders who had wanted revolution in the first place.²⁸

Already in early April, after the Reds had lost the important city of Tampere, and German troops arrived in Finland to fight on the side of the Whites, it had become evident to both parties that the Whites would win the war. When the last unit of the Red Guards surrendered in early May, the ordeal was anything but over for the Reds. Also referred to as ‘Red Russkies’, the Reds were treated as outlaws rather than as legitimate combatants in a war, and between May and October, approximately 8,000 of them were executed (roughly 10 per cent). As many as 80,000 Reds and their suspected sympathisers were also incarcerated in massive prison camps, where many died because of malnutrition, poor hygiene, and infectious diseases. The rationale for this massive retribution was to set a brutal example and ‘to terrorise the Red elements into

(land, capital, resources). Pertti Haapala, ‘The Expected and Non-expected Roots of Chaos:

Preconditions of the Finnish Civil War’, in Tepora and Roselius, *The Finnish Civil War*, 21-50, 31.

²⁸ Juha Siltala, *Sisällissodan psykohistoria* (Helsinki, 2009), 121-123.

submission'.²⁹ Altogether, nearly 30,000 Reds died either during or after the war, while only 5,000 Whites perished, so the overwhelming majority of fatalities in the war were Reds or sympathetic to socialism.³⁰ The socialists truly paid a high price for their revolutionary fervor.

As soon as the war erupted, newspapers on both sides had begun to tell stories and spread rumours about killings, tortures, and executions committed by the other side. Unfortunately, while there is very little evidence of torture, what made the Civil War so ugly was the series of impromptu executions on both sides. Stories about the brutal behaviour of the enemy ignited the spirit of revenge and stirred a mutual hatred.³¹ Then, once the Reds were defeated and authors sympathetic to the Whites started to write about the war, they were attracted to the seemingly objective, rational and scientific theory of social behaviour provided by Gustave Le Bon and other crowd psychologists.

4. Crowd psychology's appeal for Finnish-speakers and the Finnish-minded

In early May, a few days before the war ended, a Finnish-minded writer and intellectual called Volter Kilpi wrote about the 'foundation stones of the future' in the moderately conservative newspaper 'New Day' (*Uusi Päivä*). In his article, Kilpi's basic message was that monarchy was superior to republicanism. He warned about the dangers of democratic republicanism, one of which was the ignorant and illusory beliefs of the masses. To let the crowd rule, as democracy

²⁹ Siltala, 'Dissolution and Reintegration', 15.

³⁰ Tuomas Tepora and Aapo Roselius, 'Introduction', in Tepora and Roselius, *The Finnish Civil War*, 1-20, 2.

³¹ For more on the White and Red Terror, see Marko Tikka, 'Warfare and Terror in 1918', in Tepora and Roselius, *The Finnish Civil War*, 90-118.

would have it, he argued, would be to simply allow ephemeral desires and immediate material needs and wants to rule society. A society governed by the majority would fall prey to oppressive dictatorship driven by ‘naïve, fanatical self-confidence, innocent ignorance and the hard armour of “holy simplicity”’.³² Kilpi made it clear that the defeat of the Reds should signal the end of democratic republicanism or mob rule, as he saw it.

The incentive for voicing such a distrust of democracy was that it appealed to both Finnish- and Swedish-speaking conservatives, who strongly believed in the benevolence of Imperial Germany because it had lent crucial political and military support to the Whites, allowing them to crush the Reds in Helsinki and occupy the city in April. In many respects, Southern Finland had thus become a protectorate of Germany. Kilpi was one of several Germanophile authors who would have liked Finland to change into a monarchy allied with Germany – to the extent that the future king of Finland would be German. However, this monarchic ‘project’ would be abruptly terminated in October, when Emperor Wilhelm II fled Germany and the Imperial Reich collapsed. This was a heavy blow to the monarchists, who were a leading faction in Parliament and had already found a candidate for the King of Finland in the Prince of Hessen.³³

In his book on the ‘future of the nation’, published later in 1918, Kilpi referred to the ‘brutal murders’ committed by the Reds as an act of ‘acute group insanity’ and claimed that any preferences for a parliamentary republic were the result of mass suggestion in which people had been infected with arbitrary opinions. He believed the ‘Red Movement’ was not so much a

³² Volter Kilpi, ‘Tulevaisuuden peruskivet’, *Uusi Päivä*, May 2, 1918, 1. This and any subsequent translations are by the author of this article.

³³ Marjaliisa Hentilä and Seppo Hentilä, *1918 - Das deutsche Finnland: Die Rolle der Deutschen im finnischen Unabhängigkeitskrieg* (Bad Vilbel, 2018); Anders Huldén, *Finnlands deutsches Königsabenteuer 1918* (Berlin, 1997).

crime against the nation, as a national disaster or disease that needed to be healed, not punished.³⁴

The day after Kilpi's article was published, the poet V.A. Koskenniemi wrote in the same newspaper about the 'magical power of words'. In his article, Koskenniemi referred to Le Bon, whose ideas he used in his discussion of the 'psychology of the criminal mass movement' (i.e., Red Guards and their leaders). He claimed that, in its madness and bloodthirsty rage, this movement was quite unique in the history of the nation. Decent working men had been roused by the antagonistic, suggestive rhetoric of socialist demagogues in Parliament, in newspapers, and at political gatherings, which had turned them into traitors and murderers. As a poet (and influential man of letters), Koskenniemi paid particular attention to key words used pejoratively by the Left, such as 'bourgeois' (*porvari*), which was a common derogatory left-wing term for those they felt were class enemies. Koskenniemi noted how socialists associated *porvari* with a parasitic social existence, oppression, cruelty, greed, and treachery, and he added drily that, even if the worker does not believe that God exists, he certainly believes the Devil does, and the Devil is bourgeois. Another, even more derogatory socialist term used to refer to the Whites was *lahtari*, which meant 'slaughterer'. Koskenniemi argued that these and other such terms were being used by socialists to incite hatred against the 'class enemy'. Using Le Bon's ideas, he claimed that the 'masses' were acting under the hypnotic spell of Bolshevik 'group suggestion', and so their activities had no relation whatsoever to objective reality. Writing a few days before the end of the war, he wrote in the present tense about how, together with their

³⁴ Volter Kilpi, *Tulevaisuuden edessä* (Porvoo, 1918), 89, 131, 278. The study of the literary scholar Maria-Liisa Kunnas shows that virtually all major novelists and writers, Kilpi and Koskenniemi included, supported the Whites. Maria-Liisa Kunnas, *Kansalaissodan kirjalliset rintamat* (Helsinki, 1986).

leaders, who are themselves aroused by a collective frenzy, the worker masses are driven to madness and criminality.³⁵

In his article, Koskenniemi refers approvingly to another Finnish advocate of Le Bon's ideas, Leonard Åström, who in a recent magazine article had described his fellow Finns as unusually susceptible to frenzied madness.³⁶ Åström was exceptionally well-versed in crowd psychology, had worked as a teacher and journalist, and was a commissioner at the Chamber of Commerce in Tampere, one of Finland's most industrialised centres, when war broke out and the Reds took control of the town. In general, most members of the middle classes, such as writers, men of letters, academics, and high-ranking civil servants, lived in the south of Finland, which had been controlled by the Reds from the start of the war until April. Supporters of the Whites in these areas thus had a first-hand experience of what it was like to live under the command of the revolutionaries. Åström, who later became a diplomat and ambassador to the United States (committing suicide in 1939), obviously used his wide reading to good effect, because in the spring and summer of 1918 he wrote a whole book on the 'psychopathological and social-psychological aspects of the Red Guard movement'. In this book, Åström referred to several crowd psychology experts, including Le Bon, Bekhterev, McDougall, Ribot, and Lombroso. Regarding Le Bon, he wrote that 'I once heard someone call *Joukkosielu* [*The Crowd*] the Bible of our socialist agitators'.³⁷ At this point he pointedly laments the fact that Le Bon's book happens to be the only work of social psychology that had thus far been translated into Finnish,

³⁵ V.A. Koskenniemi, 'Sanojen taikamahti', *Uusi Päivä*, May 3, 1918, 3.

³⁶ Koskenniemi, 'Sanojen taikamahti', 3. Koskenniemi wrote a favorable review of Åström's book: V.A. Koskenniemi, 'Review of L. Åström, *Valtiollisia seikkailijoita*', *Uusi Päivä*, August 15, 1918, 3.

³⁷ L. Åström, *Valtiollisia seikkailijoita* (Helsinki, 1918).

and criticises it for limiting its focus exclusively to primitive instincts and emotion-based forms of social activity, which in Åström's view are actually obstacles to social progress and organisation. In other words, by reading Le Bon, socialist leaders had learned only how to incite primitive group madness among the workers, rather than guiding them into constructive cooperation and deliberative forms of communication and participation.³⁸

Åström gave vent to his feelings of shock at the Red Rebellion already on the first page of the book, where he declared that it was the 'greatest crime ever committed in the world'. He went on to describe the rebellion as 'group madness' and 'political madness', and he claimed that this pathological condition was triggered by Russian Bolshevism with the 'prophets' Lenin and Trotsky as the main culprits.³⁹ Through such mindless agitation, a creeping madness would begin to infect the workers, particularly the poorest segment of the *Lumpenproletariat*. The ignorant masses were being led astray by simpleminded journalists and agitators who postured as prophets and trumpeted the message that the proper tool for the betterment of society is the rifle.⁴⁰ Like Koskenniemi, Åström points out that, for years, and with great pathos, the socialist press and politicians had been accusing the *porvaristo* ('bourgeoisie') of being 'social beasts', while the murderous revolutionaries – often the very dregs of society – were being hailed as heroes.

Diagnosing these disorders like a doctor, Åström presented his views in a relatively objective, dispassionate manner; equipped with the tools of European mental medicine, psychology, and criminology, he aimed to calmly analyse the disease, its symptoms, and its causes. Yet, between the lines, and all the sophisticated language, there are unmistakable traces of disbelief and

³⁸ Åström, *Valtiollisia*, 91-92.

³⁹ Åström, *Valtiollisia*, 5, 98.

⁴⁰ Åström, *Valtiollisia*, 16-17.

horror.⁴¹ Åström clearly needed to find a plausible answer to the burning question of how the Civil War could have happened in a civilised nation that should have been able to solve its political and social problems without regressing to the level of violent savages.

This was a question that haunted many Finns. The spiralling violence of mass shootings and the often-merciless treatment of the captured enemy soldiers was hard to fathom for those who saw Finland as a part of civilised Europe. ‘Time and time again’, ran a note written by Lauri Ingman (MP and Professor of Theology, later Prime Minister and also Lutheran Archbishop), ‘you keep on asking yourself, how can this be possible?’⁴² This was a typical reaction of the non-partisan educated middle and upper middle classes (*Bildungsbürgertum*).

The last example of a Finnish-language literary reaction to the Civil War in the period immediately following it is Albert J. Soveri’s booklet ‘On the Mental Life of Crowds’ (*Joukkojen sielunelämästä*, 1918). Soveri was a priest, teacher of religion, and author of mostly theological texts. Among the Finnish adepts to crowd psychology, he was probably the most devoted follower of Le Bon – a subtitle even makes a direct reference to him (‘According to Le Bon’). In the early pages of his booklet, he writes how the Red Rebellion was a perfect example of crowd psychology phenomena.

⁴¹ One commentator who saw through Åström’s psycho-medical posturing was the social-democratic trade union activist E.K. Louhikko, who in his memoirs remembers how, upon reading Åström’s book (probably in late 1918), he was struck by how eager the author was to prove that socialist leaders were ‘Lombrosoan born criminals’ intent on leading the nation to ruin: ‘I have heard that, when Mr Åström later became a minister [actually, an ambassador] and had to assume a broader perspective on the world, he was a bit of ashamed of his booklet written in the midst of a frenzied time.’ E.K. Louhikko, *Teimme vallankumousta* (Helsinki, 1943), 247.

⁴² Quoted in Juri Nummelin, *Sisällissodan ääniä* (Helsinki, 2018), 55.

Following Le Bon's idea of psychic contagion, Soveri describes how ideas can be as contagious as emotions, provided that people are receptive to the message they convey. This is what happened with Bolshevism (and its counterpart, patriotism), which then divided the nation into two antagonistic camps. Like the other authors mentioned so far, Soveri attributes the receptivity of Bolshevik ideas to negative aspects of the Finnish national character, such as envy, suspicion, and the propensity to explode with fury. Excited by these 'collective feelings', revolutionary socialists who might well be good-natured and peaceful as individuals, were driven to commit horrible crimes. In psychological terms, they were under the spell of collective hypnosis, and their behaviour became machine-like in its mental automatism.⁴³ In such a state, individuals lost their usual sense of responsibility and became slaves instead to an irrational group mentality and socialist dogma, which then became like a religious creed. This phenomenon, wrote Soveri, would explain the lust for revenge and destruction that characterised the Red Rebellion. While paying close attention to the Reds' 'mania for murder', Soveri remains silent about the winning side's equally destructive 'lust for revenge' and the impromptu executions of thousands of Reds and their supporters that they carried out directly after the war.⁴⁴

Soveri suggested that an analysis of the rebellion would be useful in the coming years to ensure that more of 'the masses' would participate in the joint construction of the nation. In effect, this was a plea (also expressed by other conservative authors at this time) for labour and capital to be harmonised so as to better reunite the country after the discord and divisions of civil war. He also acknowledges that economic grievances played a role in the crowd psychology of the

⁴³ Soveri, *Joukkojen*, 19-23.

⁴⁴ Tikka, 'Warfare and Terror', 108-117.

Red Rebellion⁴⁵ – even if none of the anti-socialist authors' texts (Soveri's included) show any manifest inclination to discuss the war from an overtly sociological, historical, or economic perspective.

One reason for this disinclination among Finnish-minded authors to pursue such a perspective, was that Fennomania was a traditionally conservative movement defending the 'agrarian and corporate societal structure against the threats of industrialization'.⁴⁶ The emergence of the 'Young Fennomans', however, caused the more conservative Finnish Party (established 1905) to splinter into two rival factions, with the more upper-class, liberal-minded, urban and internationalist Young Finnish Party establishing itself in 1906. This political and cultural liberalism, in turn, had supporters among the Swedish-speaking *Bildungsbürgertum*. Swedish-speaking liberals were opposed to the monistic Fennoman ideology of 'one nation, one language', while the conservative Fennomans were not just anti-socialist, but also advocated a degree of state-centred anti-liberalism and anti-democracy – this clearly affected their portrayal of the Reds, the aborted revolution, and the workers' movement. For the liberal faction, however, economic freedom, constitutionalism, and the cultural legacy of the long era when Finland had been part of Sweden was more important to them than language.⁴⁷

⁴⁵ Soveri, *Joukkojen*, 5, 36.

⁴⁶ Alapuro, *State and Revolution*, 93.

⁴⁷ Alapuro, *State and Revolution*, 89-92.

5. Race, the masses, and the Swedish-speaking elite's decline

During the latter half of the nineteenth century, the Swedish-speaking elite began to worry about the nationalist movement that glorified Finnishness.⁴⁸ Alarmed by the 'Fennoman' notion of one nation, one language (i.e., Finnish), a sense of separate Swedish-Finnish nationhood began to develop. Essential negative ingredients in this new identity were fear and anxiety: upper-class Swedish Finns were anxious about losing their economic and political power and about Swedish losing its status as the national language. Some even feared that Swedish Finns would become extinguished as a race. The parliamentary reforms of 1906 considerably weakened the official position of Swedish Finns: in the traditional Diet-based political system, they had dominated two of the four estates (nobility and the bourgeoisie), but now that they had been forced to organise themselves around the Swedish People's Party (*Svenska Folkpartiet*), their political influence dwindled at a stroke. In the first parliamentary elections of 1907, the Party received only 12.6 per cent of the vote – a meagre result compared to the Finnish Party (27.3 per cent) and the Social Democrats (37 per cent). Relations between the language groups worsened after parliamentary reform and once the Finnish-speaking working-class became politically organised.

One reaction of Swedish Finns to their weakening prestige and the threat of Finnish nationalism was to see a sharp racial biological and psychological differentiation between the two language groups. Some members of the Swedish-speaking elite began to oppose the Finnish language, look down on Finnish culture and make claims about the racial superiority of Swedish Finns. In this new Swedish-Finn 'identity politics', Swedish speakers were the 'thinking people' – the guardians and transmitters of culture – while Finnish speakers were 'feeling people' who had a

⁴⁸ On nationalism during the autonomy (1809-1917), see Alapuro, *State and Revolution*, esp.

weaker will and lower intelligence. Racially, Swedish speakers represented the superior Germanic or Nordic race, while Finnish speakers were from further east – of Mongol, Turan, or (from the mid-1920s onwards) East Baltic descent.⁴⁹ Moreover, Finnishness began to be associated with socialism, collectivism, and a strong susceptibility to indoctrination: Finns were uncritical in their fascination with ideas.⁵⁰ A sign of the times was the 1908 Swedish encyclopaedia (*Nordisk Familjebok*), in which the entry for ‘Finns’ described the two races in Finland as the ‘Mongolian Finns’ and ‘Caucasian Swedes’.⁵¹ In this historical setting, Swedish Finns applied crowd psychology not only to the Reds, socialists, and working class, but to the whole of the Finnish-speaking population with its particular racial-ethnic characteristics. This ‘racialist’ thinking was a major difference between the Swedish-speaking and Finnish-speaking authors discussed in the previous section. ‘Swedes’ were inclined to use racial categories and see themselves as superior to the ‘Finns’, while the latter usually avoided race biology, as the ‘Finnish race’ had an inferior position in the hierarchy of races.⁵²

A typical example of the confluence of science and politics in the writings of Swedish Finns is an article written in 1919 by the pioneer geneticist Harry Federley. He was the foremost representative in Finland of eugenics and the idea of racial hygiene (or betterment). Eugenics

⁴⁹ The idea that Finns belong to the ‘East Baltic’ race was suggested by the private scholar Rolf Nordenstreng, a Swedish-speaking Finn who had moved to Sweden in 1900. Rolf Nordenstreng, *Euroopan ihmisrodut ja kansat* (Helsinki, 1929), 100-102, 310-311.

⁵⁰ Sten Högnäs, *Kustens och skogarnas folk: om synen på svenskt och finskt lynne* (Stockholm, 1995), 7-14.

⁵¹ Högnäs, *Kustens och skogarnas folk*, 61.

⁵² For more on the international discussion of the Finnish ‘race’, see Aira Kemiläinen, *Finns in the Shadow of the ‘Aryans’: Race Theories and Racism* (Helsinki, 1998).

found a receptive audience initially among some Swedish-speaking physicians in the 1910s, then Finnish-speaking physicians and academics in the 1920s, and eventually caused a law to be passed in 1935 which sanctioned forced sterilisation.⁵³ In his article, Federley's main point is that nature (biology) is not egalitarian, and he clothed this thesis in the new language of genetics. If a 'genotype' determines individual traits, and this genetic foundation is inferior, he argued, there is no way to remedy the problem through education or other environmental influences. As a consequence, among the civilized peoples of Europe, there are unfortunately more than a few who are only marginally above the mental level of savages; yet the democratic world view demands that these inferior groups be given the same political rights as superior citizens. To Federley, this was obviously the wrong solution, and the only way to eliminate their misfortune altogether was to eugenically prevent the inferior from passing their bad seeds on to future generations; the alternative of social levelling was a far greater danger. 'From the race biological perspective', Federley warned, 'the universal franchise with its direct voting rights involves a danger to society'.⁵⁴

If the link between the Red Guards and social levelling was implicit in Federley, it was made explicit in an article by poet and aristocrat Bertel Gripenberg (later nominated for the 1931 Nobel Prize in Literature). Gripenberg, who been involved in the war efforts of the Whites, proclaimed in August 1918 that the motley crew of 'Red bandits' had totally discredited the idea of equality. 'One is even tempted to see the root cause of all conflicts in the strivings to achieve equality that for decades have been openly at play in this country', he added. For him,

⁵³ Marjatta Hietala, 'From Race Hygiene to Sterilization: The Eugenics Movement in Finland'. In *Eugenics and the Welfare State: Norway, Sweden, Denmark, and Finland.*, ed. Gunnar Broberg and Nils Roll-Hansen (East Lansing, MI, 2005), 195-258.

⁵⁴ Harry Federley, 'Demokratiska idéer i biologisk betydelse', *Nya Argus* 12, no. 6 (1919): 44-45.

all that the Civil War of 1918 had shown was it was nothing but folly to try and make ‘a thug and a man of honour, a madman and a sage equal’.⁵⁵ Straight after the destruction of the Civil War, it was obvious that authors such as Gripenberg were appealing to the feelings of antipathy and retribution harboured by many of the (especially Swedish-speaking) elite towards the working class, particularly the Finnish-speaking socialist ‘masses’. However, just as there were liberally minded Swedish Finns who did not accept eugenic and race biological explanations of social behaviour and natural hierarchies,⁵⁶ there were also Finnish-minded authors who criticised the low intellectual and cultural level of the Finnish-speaking masses.⁵⁷ There was therefore some overlap between the two linguistic groups, but, as the next section reveals, there were also some distinct dissimilarities in their ideas about crowd psychology.

6. Crowd psychology for the Swedish Finns

In late November 1917, the Svekoman ethnologist, Karl Robert Villehard Wikman – then working as an archivist at the Society of Swedish Literature in Finland – wrote a short article for the *Östsvensk Tidskrift* (‘Journal of Eastern Sweden’) explaining the restlessness of that autumn by pointing to the dangers of social-democratic leadership and the socialist ‘masses’. As its title would suggest, the journal was a mouthpiece for Swedish nationalism – Wikman was not only on the journal’s editorial board, but also a member of the more radical nationalist

⁵⁵ Bertel Gripenberg, ‘Hvarför segrade de hvita?’, *Finsk Tidskrift* 85 (1918), 149-155, 153.

⁵⁶ On the pages of *Nya Argus* in 1922, race biology and its political implications were challenged by two academic critics who were very skeptical of what they saw as the overgeneralized claims of Federley and other race biologists.

⁵⁷ See e.g. Kilpi, *Tulevaisuuden edessä*; Åström, *Valtiollisia seikkailijoita*; and the writer Eino Leino’s autobiographical novel *Helsingin valloitus* (Helsinki, 1918).

wing of the Swedish People's Party. His brief account of the civil unrest and the recent General Strike referred to crowd psychology, but it did not mention Le Bon or any other crowd psychologist by name. Instead, it referred to 'mass psychology' and how socialists were particularly prone to the psychological virus of 'Russian mass psychosis'. Coming out barely two months before the outbreak of the Civil War, Wikman was clearly alarmed at how the very recent Bolshevik revolution in Russia had set a dangerous precedent, as he referred to Finnish socialist activities as 'revolution'.⁵⁸

Six months later, with the Civil War already over, a young writer and scholar called Hans Ruin wrote an article about 'mass psychology' in the cultural magazine *Nya Argus*. Ruin suggested that it was now high time to explore the 'mysterious phenomenon' of 'the mass psyche'. Referring to Le Bon, Ruin described how people could lose their individuality and become part of the collective mind, which – without the detachment necessary for reason – is prone to go berserk. In this condition, the individual psyche is totally susceptible to suggestion, which on a group level amounts to mass psychosis. Accusing the socialist press as agitators, liars and madmen for poisoning the 'mental atmosphere' of society, he claimed that 'never before in the history of humanity has a class of people [*folkklass*] been exposed to such systematic deception, such unscrupulous agitation, such shameless courting of the worst instincts [as in this rebellion]'.⁵⁹ Socialist leaders had sown the seeds of hate across the country, so they merited the harshest sentence possible under criminal law. But the rank-and-file would also have to pay the price if they had acted as thieves, pillagers, and murderers. Even if many of them had been victims of mass psychosis, once their crimes were exposed and they were found guilty, they could no longer be members of society.

⁵⁸ K. Rob. V. Wikman, 'Massans politiker', *Östsvensk Tidskrift* 1, no. 23-24 (1917): 174-176.

⁵⁹ Hans Ruin, 'Litet masspsykologi', *Nya Argus* 11, no. 6-8 (1918): 40-43, 42.

Nevertheless, Ruin did not believe that sentencing tens of thousands of former Reds to long-term forced labour was the answer. This mass punishment (which was publicly being discussed) would only create widespread bitterness, the consequences of which were unforeseeable. Whatever the punishment was to be, it needed to correspond with what the people thought justified – as they gradually became aware of the magnitude of crimes committed.⁶⁰

Another humanist scholar, the historian Per Olof von Törne, claimed that age-old ‘national maladies’ (*folksjudomar*) among Finns had been aroused by skilful socialist leaders via mass psychosis. One specific psychosis revolved around the delusion that the *porvaristo* were arming themselves to annihilate the working class.⁶¹ A more ‘professional’ crowd psychologist was the writer, translator, and scholar Henning Söderhjelm who, in 1913, had discussed human instincts and feelings from the psychological perspective in his doctoral dissertation. In 1918, he wrote a book on the Civil War that was translated and published in many European countries, including England.⁶² As was customary in Swedish language civil war literature, the Finnish ‘national spirit’ (*folksjäl*) had explanatory power in Söderhjelm’s book: he characterised the Finns as ‘dogged, tenacious, stubborn’, and described the Finn as a ‘primitive individualist’ and ‘hermit’, who ‘lives for himself only’ and is suspicious of strangers.⁶³ His description of the workers’ movement was also in line with the general trend in White literature: he wrote about how the SDP

⁶⁰ Ruin, ‘Litet masspsykologi’, 43.

⁶¹ P.O. von Törne, *Stundens krav* (Helsingfors, 1918), 14-15.

⁶² Henning Söderhjelm, *The Red Insurrection in Finland in 1918* (London: [Publication year not given; probably published in the early 1920s]), viii.

⁶³ Söderhjelm, *The Red Insurrection*, 1-2.

never succeeded in securing any honest, upright and trustworthy leaders. Its touring lecturers, stump orators and editors were, almost without exception, persons of weak character [...]. The work of agitation against the ‘upper class’ had left a sediment of dark hatred in their hearts against all other classes.⁶⁴

Again, like virtually every supporter of the Whites, he claimed that the decisive step towards revolution was taken when the ‘most violent’ Reds began to cooperate with the Russian Bolsheviks (in 1917). This Bolshevik influence was described as the ‘Russian infection’ in terms reminiscent of ‘psychic infection’ and ‘mental suggestion’ used in other accounts. What this cooperation and the increasingly hostile attitude towards the middle classes brought about was ‘mob rule’.⁶⁵ Fortunately, the insurgents were defeated, and the victory of law and order over chaos and terror signified the triumph of western culture in Finland over the Bolshevik threat from the east.⁶⁶

To the physician Lars Ringbom, crowd psychology was absolutely essential – he even identified himself as a crowd (and race) psychologist. Although he lacked academic credentials (like Le Bon), one of his books was published in England. His first book, however, was published in the autumn of 1918 and dealt with the Civil War and sported an apt subtitle: ‘psychological notes’ (*psykologiska anteckningar*). On the very first page of the book, he referred to the Swedish translation of Le Bon’s *Crowd*. His other intellectual debt was to psychoanalysis, and soon after mentioning Le Bon he started to discuss Sigmund Freud and Alfred Adler’s ideas of hysteria, complex, and compensation – in the Preface, he called his book ‘an attempt to psychoanalyse the *folksjäl* [national spirit]’. Using concepts from crowd and depth psychology, he began his

⁶⁴ Söderhjelm, *The Red Insurrection*, 10-11.

⁶⁵ Söderhjelm, *The Red Insurrection*, 21.

⁶⁶ Söderhjelm, *The Red Insurrection*, 158-159.

inquiry into the ‘group mind’ and ‘collective consciousness’ of the masses by presenting the failed revolution as a ‘psychological riddle’ which demanded a solution.⁶⁷

Ringbom’s solution was straight-forward – the Reds were basically mad. More specifically they suffered from paranoia. In Ringbom’s diagnosis, this mental illness was caused by socialist agitation that had managed to confuse minds that were already, after many years of aggressive demagoguery, prone to accepting and internalising extreme suggestions. In an excited state of mass psychosis, there was a growing sense of paranoia that the *porvaristo* were ‘slaughterers’ who would persecute the working class and try to starve them to death. And when these slaughterers formed militias to protect themselves, their goal was perceived to be ‘mass murder’ of the workers. The violent week of the General Strike in November 1917 already hinted at what was in store for the class enemy. In January 1918, the ‘murder ecstasy’ of the Reds evolved into a ‘murder epidemic’. Within this psycho-medical framework, Ringbom actually relinquished the Reds from any responsibility for their actions: in their ‘abnormal’ mental state, they did not know what they were doing when they took up arms and started a revolution. In contrast to many other White authors, Ringbom claimed that the socialist leaders were mentally incompetent too, because they were as susceptible to the influence of the masses as the masses were to them, so the leaders’ sense of responsibility was as damaged as those they led. He ends his book by making the concrete suggestion that posters should be put up in public places – at the side of the street, by train tracks, virtually everywhere in fact – with the words, ‘the reign of hate is over’, written on them in both Finnish and Swedish.⁶⁸

As well as using crowd psychology as his interpretative framework, Ringbom was also keen on differentiating between individualism and collectivism, so much so that in virtually all of his

⁶⁷ Lars Ringbom, *Inbördeskriget i Finland: psykologiska anteckningar* (Helsingfors, 1918), 101.

⁶⁸ Ringbom, *Inbördeskriget*, 141.

subsequent publications he would bring up the topic.⁶⁹ He used individualism and collectivism as two diametrically opposed ways of being in the world, and as a means to describe individuals, groups and nations. The Slavs, like the Chinese, for example, were a typically collectivist people, who attached little importance to individual will and initiative. From the perspective of crowd psychology, collectivist peoples had a strong sense of togetherness, were more feminine, and so more emotional than individualists. Their emotionality in turn made them very receptive to suggestion – when ‘suggestion’ is defined as a ‘transfer of emotion’ from one person or group to another person or group. In contrast, the English and the Swedes were thoroughly individualistic people, for whom a sense of liberty and self-reliance were part and parcel of their mental disposition.⁷⁰

To Ringbom, collectivism is therefore the key to the riddle of the Red Rebellion: as the Finns were a collectivist people, with partly eastern racial characteristics, the worker masses were receptive to a doctrine that arose out of the collectivist Russian mentality. Although he acknowledges that it is ‘to a large degree’ thanks to socialism that the ‘thinking man’ has learned about acute social problems, the Civil War would never have broken out had the workers not been influenced by socialist doctrines. The main reason the war *did* break out could be found in the workings of the Finnish (and Russian) national spirit: the minds of the masses were susceptible to ‘psycho-infection’ – in other words the indoctrination and agitation of socialist leaders.⁷¹ This susceptibility was characteristic of Russians and other collectivist peoples, including the Finnish-speaking Finns, whose ‘emotional life’ was ‘extraordinarily

⁶⁹ See, for example, Lars Ringbom, *Stridande makter och stridiga mål* (Helsingfors, 1921); and *The Culture of Renewal* (London, 1929).

⁷⁰ Ringbom, *Stridande makter*, 106.

⁷¹ Ringbom, *Inbördeskriget*, 68-69.

intensive’ – as he puts it in his 1921 monograph.⁷² As representatives of the Finnish race, Ringbom argues, the Red Guards were especially collectivist-minded (perhaps choosing to ignore that there were also Swedish-speaking Finns among them).⁷³

As we have seen, there were differences in the ways the two linguistic groups applied crowd psychology in their interpretation of events. Swedish Finns, for instance, referred to the ‘national spirit’ (*folksjäl*) in their search for explanations of the rebellion, and they were more inclined to use racial categories to differentiate not only between ‘us’ (Whites) and ‘them’ (Reds), but also between the German or Nordic race and Finnish, East Baltic, or Mongol race. In short, many Swedish Finns combined crowd psychology with race psychology and biology to underline the point that the Red Rebellion had been caused (implicitly or explicitly) by the inferior racial characteristics of the Finns. Furthermore, they tended to be concerned for the future of the Swedish language and, by extension, the culture of Swedish speakers in Finland. What united the two linguistic groups, however, was the common belief that Russians and Russian Bolshevism were not only a threat to western civilization, but that socialists were inciting ‘class hatred’ among workers. To the Whites, the war signified a fight against Red delusion and Russian Bolsheviks, so it was a war *for* freedom rather than *against* the

⁷² Ringbom, *Stridande makter*, 77.

⁷³ For more on the role of ethnolinguistic aspects in the Civil War, see Pekka Kalevi Hamalainen, *In Time of Storm: Revolution, Civil War, and the Ethnolinguistic Issue in Finland* (Albany, NY, 1978).

revolutionaries as such – a ‘war of liberation’ not only from Russian rule, but also from the terrifying prospect of Bolshevism.⁷⁴

7. The appeal of crowd psychology in Finland after the Civil War

Arguably, there were three main reasons for the popularity of crowd psychology immediately after the Civil War. First of all, the war deeply upset the middle classes. Although relations between the workers’ movement and parties of the middle classes had certainly deteriorated in the decade following the General Strike of 1905, socialist attempts to start a revolution in 1918 came as a great shock. In this state of bewilderment the Whites attributed the proximate cause of the revolution to the irrational – i.e. not politically or socially legitimate – behaviour of the insurgents.⁷⁵ After being surrounded, controlled, and in many cases bullied by the revolutionaries for weeks or months during the war, these middle-class writers, who had tolerated house searches and impudent behaviour from these lower class Reds, were unable to assume a dispassionate, analytic frame of mind when they took up pen and started to give expression to their thoughts and sentiments. For many, the events they wrote about were still too close for comfort, and the emotional distance from the war was too short for coolly analysing what had happened. In fact, the time was only ripe for truly dispassionate analyses of

⁷⁴ For more on the hatred of Russians at the time of the Civil War, see Outi Karemaa, *Vihollisia, vainoojia, syöpäläisiä: venäläisviha Suomessa 1917-1923* (Helsinki, 1998), English summary: *Foes, fiends and vermin: ethnic hatred of Russians in Finland 1917-1923*.

⁷⁵ As Risto Alapuro has noted, the Civil War ‘remained nearly totally incomprehensible to the intelligentsia’. Risto Alapuro, ‘Coping with the Civil War of 1918 in Twenty-First Century Finland’, in *Historical Injustice and Democratic Transition in Eastern Asia and Northern Europe*, ed. Kenneth Christie and R.B. Cribb (London, 2002), 169-183, 171.

the Civil War by the 1960s and 1970s – until then, all accounts of the war were coloured by the partisan ideological and political standpoints of authors, whether socialist or anti-socialist.⁷⁶ This apparent reluctance or sheer incapacity to offer a more or less objective account of the Civil War was not unique to Finland – the same was true of the Spanish Civil War, which is perhaps the one civil war in twentieth-century Europe that most resembles the Finnish Civil War.⁷⁷

The second reason is related to the first insofar as it also centres on socialism and the working class. It could be called the spectre of socialism, but what was really at play here was the arrival of the organised working class onto the political scene in the first decade of the century. By the stormy year of 1917, events and incidents (such as the General Strike) in the autumn, aggravated the political situation and, in effect, created the two antagonistic camps that became contenders in the political struggle and eventually the war. The upper classes were also divided into two camps on the question of the new nation's language and, by extension, power. The underlying political and social tensions of an industrialising society, which had built up since 1905, meant the ground was now fertile for portraying the other party as an enemy. As a result, while the Whites were described by the Reds as slaughterers and capitalist bloodsuckers, for the majority of Whites, the Reds were outlaws at best, a despicable mob at worst.

⁷⁶ On the legacy of the Civil War in twentieth-century Finland, see Alapuro, 'Coping with the Civil War'.

⁷⁷ Julián Casanova, 'Civil Wars, Revolutions and Counterrevolutions in Finland, Spain, and Greece (1918-1949): A Comparative Analysis', *International Journal of Politics, Culture, and Society* 13 (2000): 515-537; Payne, *Civil War in Europe*, 25-32; Jukka Kekkonen, *Kun aseet puhuvat: Poliittinen väkivalta Espanjan ja Suomen sisällissodissa* (Helsinki, 2016).

Finally, to use crowd psychology as an explanation was to rely on scientific expertise. Specifically, what this reliance on psycho-medical theories demonstrated, was the growing popularity and scientific prestige of psychiatry and psychology in Finland. Psychiatry had only just been established as a new medical specialty at the Imperial Alexander University in 1911, and psychology was taking its first steps as a separate field from philosophy. By the early twentieth century, several books on psychiatric and psychological issues had already been published (including Le Bon's), and policy makers and various academics were increasingly advocating a rationalist form of social planning influenced by the German ethos of social engineering (*Verein für Sozialpolitik*), which dated from the last third of the nineteenth century.⁷⁸ A concrete manifestation of this 'scientisation of the social',⁷⁹ was the establishment of special committees appointed and convened by the government for analysing and discussing issues in anticipation of proposed legislation – these governmental committees included academics who were experts in the specific field of the proposed law (for instance, there were psychiatrists in committees examining issues related to mental health care, and law professors in committees examining criminality). Especially in the interwar years, several professors were

⁷⁸ Petteri Pietikäinen, *Kipeät sielut. Hulluuden historia Suomessa* (Helsinki, 2020), 18-19, 42-46;

Risto Eräsaari & Keijo Rahkonen, eds, *Työväenkysymyksestä sosiaalipolitiikkaan* (Helsinki, 1975).

⁷⁹ The need to acquire knowledge about people's social conditions and how the social system generally functioned paved the way for a society of experts to emerge, and for the ideology and policy of 'social engineering'. See Kerstin Brückweh et al, eds, *Engineering Society. The Role of the Human and Social Sciences in Modern Societies, 1880–1980* (Houndmills, 2012); Thomas Etzemüller, ed., *Die Ordnung der Moderne. Social Engineering im 20. Jahrhundert* (Bielefeld, 2009); Yvonne Hirdmann, 'Social planning under rational control', in *Models, Modernity and the Myrdals*, ed. Pauli Kettunen and Hanna Eskola (Helsinki, 1997), 55–80.

politically active as MPs, and some were even appointed as ministers in the government. So it was that in the early years of Finland's independence, the ties between universities and political institutions were very strong.⁸⁰ Indeed, the direct political power of the *Bildungsbürgertum* was probably at its peak during the early years of the republic.

I would suggest that the psychological shock caused by the insurgence, the accumulation of political tension between the working and middle classes, and this 'scientisation of the social' are the main reasons for the popularity of crowd psychology in the aftermath of the Civil War. Judging by accounts of the war not only from conservative but also socialist authors, we should not reject the possibility that some segments of the revolutionary working class were indeed, as crowd psychology would tell us, under the 'influence of mass suggestion'. The more moderate social democrats, for instance, most of whom were imprisoned for a period of time after the war, often referred in their published accounts to the more militant and violent Red Guards in terms equally reminiscent of crowd psychology.⁸¹

⁸⁰ Seikko Eskola, 'Professorin tehtävät historian valossa'. *Acatiimi* no. 8 (2004), www.acatiimi.fi/2004/8_04/8_04d.htm (accessed 24 March 2021).

⁸¹ See Louhikko, *Teimme vallankumousta*, 145; Arvid Luhtakanta, *Suomen Punakaarti* (Kulju, 1938), 33-34; E. Huttunen, *Sosiaalidemokraattinen Puolue ja kansalaissota* (Helsinki, 1918), 98-99; Hannes Ryömä, *Vallankumousvuoden tapahtumista* (Helsinki, 1918), 19, 39. Even the hard-core communist Otto-Wille Kuusinen, a political refugee who co-founded the Finnish Communist Party in Moscow in the autumn of 1918, admitted in his account of the insurgency that there were some 'worthless windbags' as leaders and commanders in the Red Guards. Kuusinen became a prominent *apparatchik* in the Soviet Government in the 1920s. O.W. Kuusinen, *Suomen vallankumouksesta* (Pietari, 1918), 34

One such moderate socialist was the journalist and poet, Alexander Halonen, who had been an MP in the early 1910s and regional leader for the Red Guards when civil war broke out. In his account of the war (published in 1923), he strongly condemned the violence he witnessed, blaming the ‘unaware’ and ‘irresponsible’ lower-level Communist leadership for hate-filled agitation among the less enlightened and more embittered workers.⁸² A year later, Jarl von Schoultz, the first historian of the Finnish SDP, referred to Halonen’s recently published book when relating how important verbal agitation was for the early social democratic movement at the beginning of the century. Schoultz argued that the SDP soon realised a more effective way to gather support was to cultivate class hatred of the *porvaristo* rather than disseminating socialist doctrines or dwelling on the actual political goals of the party.⁸³

The role of such ‘hate speech’ in the workers’ movement has also been analysed by the historian Jari Ehrnrooth; focusing on the years 1905–1914, Ehrnrooth sheds light on the numerous references to agitation, suggestion, and hate speech that suffuse the post-war accounts of both conservative and social democrat (but not communist) authors. Using the writings of ‘doctrinal preceptors’ as well as the hand-written speeches and utterances of itinerant speakers at the shop-floor level, Ehrnrooth examined how socialist doctrines rejecting revolutionary voluntarism (especially those of Karl Kautsky) were replaced by a ‘justification of impatient class hatred demanding equal distribution’ for workers at the local level.⁸⁴ By 1915, there were more than 1,500 workers’ associations in Finland, which was a lot for a population of little more than three million. According to Ehrnrooth, who does not discuss crowd psychology in his book, the class

⁸² Alex. Halonen, *Suomen työväki ja väkivaltaiset menettelytavat* (Helsinki, 1923), 87.

⁸³ Jarl von Schoultz, *Bidrag till belysande av Finlands socialdemokratiska partis historia* (Helsingfors, 1924), 150-151.

⁸⁴ Jari Ehrnrooth, *Sanan vallassa, vihan voimalla* (Helsinki, 1992), 563 (English summary).

hatred was ‘aroused by directing envy and hate into the required channels [...] It appears that for the exertion of influence the channelling of hatred was the guiding principle.’⁸⁵ In addition to these workers’ associations, there were as many as 21 newspapers published by trade unions and related organisations (including several house organs), and these formed an important public channel for the workers’ movement.

However, the importance of agitation, suggestion and emotional arousal for the insurgence should not be overemphasised. Discussion of the more intellectual and doctrinaire issues were part and parcel of the workers’ movement, and there were, for example, several study groups in which relevant literature was read and discussed by members (not just socialist ideas, but also issues such as militarism and Darwinism).⁸⁶ As the studies by Ehrnrooth and the historian Juha Siltala⁸⁷ suggest, the workers’ movement was motivated by both intellectual and emotional aspects of personality. A crucial step on the road to civil war – and the moment of madness, as it were – was when the militant socialist cadres decided it was time to take up arms, crush the ‘slaughterers’, and by defeating the class enemy, make the poor and downtrodden the new rulers of the nation.

8. Conclusion

Crowd psychology had its heyday in Finland right after the Civil War. Directly after it, before the constitution of a democratic, parliamentary republic, a large number of books and articles dealt with the Red Rebellion, its causes, and explanations. As I found out in my systematic

⁸⁵ Ehrnrooth, *Sanan vallassa*, 573 (English summary).

⁸⁶ Louhikko, *Teimme vallankumousta*, 86-87.

⁸⁷ Siltala, *Sisällissodan psykohistoria*.

study of cultural periodicals and magazines from 1918 to 1939, references to Le Bon and crowd psychology had dramatically decreased by the mid-1920s. In that decade, it was mainly Lars Ringbom who carried the torch of crowd psychology. After that, its relevancy seemed to have diminished, if not vanished, even though the 1930s witnessed the rise of fascist mass movements in Europe, including Finland, where the rural based ‘Lapua Movement’ garnered mass support for a few years before it was banned and dissolved after a failed attempt to overthrow the government in 1932.⁸⁸ The Lapua Movement would have provided ample material for crowd psychology interpretations, but perhaps the conservative, anti-Communist writers did not want to make any uncomfortable comparisons between the ‘suggestible’ masses of socialist workers in 1917/18 and the ‘patriotic’ crowds that supported fascism twelve years later.

In the 1930s, international crowd psychology – now called ‘mass psychology’ – was partly revived in the Spanish philosopher José Ortega y Gasset’s *Revolt of the Masses* (*La rebelión de las masas*, 1930) and the renegade Marxist psychoanalyst Wilhelm Reich’s *Mass Psychology of Fascism* (*Die Massenpsychologie des Fascismus*, 1933). In Finland, however, crowd psychology was all but extinct by the 1930s. Internationally, a new chapter in the study of collective behaviour began after World War II, when the concept of ‘mass society’ gained ground in the social sciences. In effect, conservative crowd psychology morphed into liberal or left-leaning crowd sociology, and influential thinkers such as Hannah Arendt, C. Wright Mills

⁸⁸ Lauri Karvonen, *From White to Blue-and-Black. Finnish Fascism in the Inter-War Era* (Helsinki, 1988).

and Arthur Kornhauser offered new theoretical perspectives on modern ‘mass societies’.⁸⁹ Today, the crowd problem, psychological or otherwise, is far less relevant than it was in the early twentieth century, when, as Christian Borch has observed, ‘crowds and masses formed a central concern for a great number of sociologists’ (and psychologists).⁹⁰

What we now have are studies of Le Bon, other crowd psychologists, and famous adherents to crowd psychology, such as Hitler and Mussolini. What we lack are detailed studies of the ways in which interpretations based on crowd psychology have been used in different historical situations and settings. After all, in the *Handbook of Social Psychology* (1954), the eminent American social psychologist Gordon W. Allport wrote that ‘perhaps the most influential book ever written in social psychology is Le Bon’s *The Crowd*’.⁹¹ Seven years later, the sociologist Daniel Bell noted in his *End of Ideology* that the theory of mass society ‘is probably the most influential social theory in the Western world today’.⁹² While using the cautious words ‘perhaps’ and ‘probably’, Allport and Bell may have been right in their assessments of the significance of crowd psychology (and sociology).

⁸⁹ Hannah Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (New York, 1951); C. Wright Mills, *The Power Elite* (New York, 1956); Arthur William Kornhauser, *The Politics of Mass Society* (Glencoe, IL, 1959). For more on the development of crowd psychology into mass society theories, see Leach, ‘Mastering the Crowd’.

⁹⁰ Borch, *The Politics of Crowd*, 1.

⁹¹ Quoted in Robert Merton, ‘The Ambivalences of Le Bon’s *The Crowd*’ (Introduction), in Le Bon, *The Crowd*, v-xxxix, v.

⁹² Daniel Bell, *The End of Ideology* (Glencoe, IL, 1960), 21.

For its part, this article lends support to the thesis that crowd psychology was an influential intellectual construction that had great heuristic value among contemporaries for at least half a century. Intrinsic to Finnish interpretations of crowd psychology were (i) the increasing antagonism between socialists and anti-socialists, (ii) the influence of Bolshevism on the worker's movement, (iii) the importance attributed to 'racial' qualities of the people involved, and (iv) the impact of the Civil War on the educated classes – all of which are issues that are easy to relate to wider European and global developments. Above all, as a 'case study' of one country, this article has demonstrated how theories from crowd psychology influenced political, social, and cultural thinking during the late nineteenth and early twentieth century. Obviously, then, there is a need for further historical studies of how, and for what purposes, crowd psychology was used in twentieth-century Europe and indeed the world.

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